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Bitchat, a decentralized messaging app. Image: Bitchat/MockupTree/Decrypt

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## In brief

- Downloads of Jack Dorsey's decentralized messaging app Bitchat have surged in Nepal and Indonesia amid national protests.
- Nepal's ban on multiple social media platforms drove mass adoption of the decentralized, offline chat app, with downloads surging from 2,300 last week to

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The developer identified a "sudden spike" in Bitchat downloads in Indonesia during nationwide protests in the previous week. "Today we're seeing an even bigger spike from Nepal during youth protests over government corruption and a social media ban."

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Observers say decentralized apps offered a measure of autonomy at a time when confidence in authorities have faltered.

"Decentralized and censorship-resistant messaging applications will see an explosion in adoption," Christian Ruz, account director at crypto creative agency Hype, told *Decrypt*.

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Applications like Bitchat are “helping young people change their society, demand better living conditions, more economic opportunities, and stop corruption on a large scale,” he said, adding that decentralized apps like it could “challenge the status quo and help the people protest for better human conditions.”




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Asked about the reasons behind the protests, Iqbal said that Indonesians had hoped “the government can help in terms of initiative and policy that can support them, but because many recent policies are facing backlash from a larger audience, they felt no empathy."

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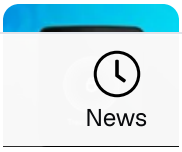


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